



Much-awaited return: Jasprit Bumrah last played a Test in Birmingham in July 2022. GETTY IMAGES

took over from Dean Elgar, whose obduracy at the top played an important role in South Africa's series victory last time.

The Proteas will rely on the experience and skills of those two batters, just as Kohli's class and intensity will be crucial to India's fortunes. In the absence of Cheteshwar Pujara and Ajinkya Rahane, the Test specialists who played in the 2021-22 series, the former captain's role in the batting line-up assumes even more significance. Kohli is the only Indian batter to average more than 50 (after playing at least 10 innings) in Tests in South Africa. He has also scored two hundreds; only Sachin Tendulkar has more (five).

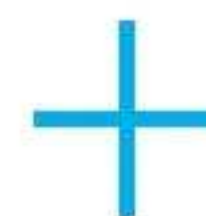
The Indian think tank wouldn't mind Kohli adding to his tally of hundreds. Neither would it mind some handsome contributions from

skipper Rohit. He may have gone past 40 only once in his eight previous Test innings in South Africa, but he has arrived in the Rainbow Nation after making 103, 80, and 57 in his last three innings in the longest format in the West Indies. The numbers from his last Test series against South Africa — in India, four years ago — are even more impressive, with scores such as 176, 127, and 212.

He also has his brilliant form from the recent ODI World Cup to lean on. Even in not the most ideal conditions

for batting, as in the final against Australia in Ahmedabad, he played with a freedom and confidence that very few others have shown. Batting on the lively tracks of South Africa against a battery of quality quick bowlers may be tougher, but he is arguably the best puller in the game since Ricky Ponting.

If Rohit gets going, so could India. After missing the 2021-22 series because of a hamstring injury, he will be keen to make use of this opportunity. K.L. Rahul had opened in that series and made a brilliant



South Africa is grappling with injuries, with Anrich Nortje already ruled out. Additionally, there are concerns about key players Kagiso Rabada and Lungi Ngidi as well.